

Allan Lee

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EDUCATION

University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA

May 2023

Bachelor of Arts in Economics; Minor in East Asian Area Studies

Honor Thesis in Economics: The Effects of Food Insecurity on Children's Cognitive Skills: Evidence from Ghana (received A)

Cumulative GPA: 3.97/4.00

Honors/Awards: Phi Beta Kappa; Winner of the 2023 Yardley Prize for best thesis on political economy (\$1,000); Dean's List (2021–2022); Selected as 1 of 9 Pre-doctoral scholars to attend the 2023 Association for Education Finance and Policy Conference

Skills: R (proficient); Stata (experienced); SQL (experienced); Python (beginner); MATLAB (beginner)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Princeton University, Senior Research Specialist under Dr. Evan Soltas, Princeton, NJ

July 2025 – Present

- Used regression discontinuity design to assess the effects of distance to zoning boundaries in LA on housing costs.
- Performed spatial merge to combine 1 million+ real estate listings with permits to study the effects of regulations on housing prices.
- (Co-author with PI) Compared 1500+ low-income housing projects across 4 states to industry-standard construction estimates to assess high costs of low-income housing.

Cornerstone Research, Analyst, New York, NY

July 2023 – May 2025

- Developed a function in R to automate the creation of 30+ charts comparing prison violence across 5+ states over time to show inter-state heterogeneity.
- Used difference-in-difference model to estimate market entry impact for a luxury automobile brand relative to competitors over time.
- Conducted a literature review of 10+ articles on the split of synergies in M&A transactions in the financial services sector.

Penn Graduate School of Education, Research Assistant for Dr. Sade Bonilla, Philadelphia, PA

September 2022 – February 2024

- Created 2-part demographics summary statistics in Stata of 600 community college students participating in an RCT assessing the effects of unconditional cash transfers on school engagement and student well-being. Current working paper at Annenberg Institute.
- Conducted a literature review of 20+ articles on college students' academic experiences, financial hardships, and mental health.
- Reviewed 40+ question Qualtrics survey sent to RCT participants regarding academic & social experiences.

Penn Graduate School of Education, Research Assistant for Dr. Sharon Wolf, Philadelphia, PA

September 2021 – May 2023

- Created sibling age ranking variables among 2K+ Ghanaian families to analyze the relationship of having an older sister on child cognitive outcomes.
- Designed charts to summarize 300+ answers regarding types of help parents offer children (e.g., homework or emotional support).
- Presented economics thesis covering principal component analysis and instrumental variables to Prof. S. Wolf and 15+ researchers.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

- **Lee, A.**, "Running with the Crowd: Peer Effects Using Evidence from Marathon Runners"
 - **Abstract**: Understanding how peer groups shape individual performance is central to the design of schools, firms, and other organizations. Existing literature has largely adopted a static perspective on peer effects, rather than examining how peers dynamically shape productivity based on work period or difficulty of task. In many real-world settings—from classrooms to workplaces—individuals must allocate effort dynamically, and peer groups may serve as salient reference points that influence not just total output but how effort is distributed over time. We exploit quasi-random variation in peer group assignment at the New York City Marathon to estimate peer effects on individual performance and pacing strategy. The New York City Marathon assigns runners to waves based on a best-pace threshold, generating a regression discontinuity in peer group composition at each cutoff. Using finisher data from 2023 to 2025 ($n=56,613$), we find that assignment to a slower wave has no significant effect on overall finishing time, but meaningfully distorts within-race pacing: runners assigned to slower waves run 1% faster than their predicted pace in the first 5K but 1% slower in 5K segments in the second half of the race. Additional heterogeneity analyses reveal that effects are largest among runners without an affinity to finishing races with round-number finish times, suggesting that peer influence is strongest when runners lack independent pacing anchors. These findings contribute to a growing literature on peer effects in competitive settings and suggest that grouping policies can shape not just total output but the intertemporal allocation of effort within a performance period.
- **Lee, A.***, **Aurino, S.**, **Wolf, S.** "Food Insecurity and Children's Cognitive and Socioemotional Skills: Whose Report Matters?"
 - **Abstract**: Two out of three children in low-income countries are affected by food insecurity. Household food insecurity is typically measured using caregiver reports, but children reports may shed light on experiences or domains of food insecurity overlooked by caregivers. Using a novel validated measure of child-reported food insecurity, we examine how both child- and caregiver-reported food insecurity predict children's academic, cognitive, and socioemotional skills in a large sample of

children (N = 3,771, ages 5–17) and their caregivers in five northern Ghana regions. Caregivers were nearly twice as likely as children to report food insecurity, with larger discrepancies across items reflecting moderate food insecurity manifestations. In value-added models that aim to control for unobserved heterogeneity driving skills, caregiver-reported food insecurity predicted lower literacy and numeracy, especially for boys and older adolescents, whereas child-reported food insecurity was not predictive of any outcome. Potential mechanisms (child health, parental educational investments, children's aspirations, and caregiver psychological well-being) partially accounted for the observed associations. Findings suggest that caregiver reports better capture the constraints induced by food insecurity on children's learning in this context, which is important information for the targeting of interventions to support child development via tackling food insecurity.

- *Bonilla, S.*, Lee, A., Minaya, V. "A Profile of Community College Students' Campus Engagement and Well-Being."*
 - **Abstract:** Community colleges play a critical role in promoting educational equity by enrolling a disproportionately high number of low-income, racially minoritized, first-generation, immigrant, and older students. However, the past decade has been marked by significant challenges that threaten the sustainability of the two-year public college sector. These include declining enrollment, increased competition from public four-year universities and for-profit schools, shifting student preferences, and a tightening labor market. The COVID-19 pandemic further exacerbated these challenges, resulting in a significant drop in community college enrollments, particularly among Black and male students. This descriptive study characterizes a first-time, low-income community college student population and investigates the relationship between students' time utilization, engagement with campus resources, financial and mental well-being, and their overall campus engagement. Our findings highlight the need for policymakers, educators, and stakeholders to prioritize resources in community colleges to ensure student success.

CONFERENCES

- 2024 Association for Education Finance and Policy (Baltimore, MD), *Presented*
- 2023 American Educational Research Association (Chicago, IL), *Presented*
- 2023 Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (Atlanta, GA), *Accepted but not presented at*

LEADERSHIP & ACTIVITIES

Reentry Debate Initiative, *Founder, Philadelphia, PA*

June 2021 – May 2023

- Reached out to 10+ reentry organizations in Pennsylvania regarding the Reentry Debate Initiative, a program where Penn debaters taught (formerly) incarcerated people debate.
- Designed a reentry debate program and taught debate to 15 incarcerated students at a Pennsylvanian state prison.
- Developed arguments for Why Not Prosper's (reentry organization) activism regarding ethical wrongs of poor prison labor standards.

Penn Debate Society, *Vice President of Training, Philadelphia, PA*

September 2019 – December 2022

- Represented Canada at the World Schools Debating Championship; finalist at the Yale APDA and USC IV debate tournaments.
- Served as director and developed a tabbing system for the 3-day UPenn World Schools Tournament (300+ participants in attendance).
- Debated with two novices in a varsity-novice and Ukraine charity debate tournament, providing them feedback and experience.

Penn Restorative Entrepreneurship Program (PREP), *Consultant, Philadelphia, PA*

July 2022 – May 2023

- Identified 15 bus stops close to Philadelphia-based prisons and their bus routes for a reentry map provided to returning citizens.
- Profiled 4 reentry organizations in PA with services such as employment support, personal mentorship, and provision of essentials.

Chinese Music Ensemble of New York, *Erhu Performer, New York, NY*

April 2024 – Present

- Rehearsed weekly with 50+ member orchestra and performed 12 songs at Kaufman Music Center for ~500 attendees.
- Created 2-minute music video parody of *The Office* theme song played on the Erhu for college talent show.
- Recorded Chinese classical music *Galloping Horses* and *Peaceful Night* in traditional instrument Erhu duo for virtual performance.

INTERESTS

writing music; filmmaking; sourdough; running (training for NYC & London marathon)